

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

snapcoalition.org/
Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track E Education Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 E track: Education. Design a policy response to a K-12 or higher-ed problem for a specific state or district.

Use Case Description:

This challenge asks teams to design a policy response to a K-12 or higher-education problem for a specific state or district context.

Problem Statement:

Designing a policy response to a K-12 or higher-education problem.

- Select a focus: learning loss/literacy recovery, teacher shortage & retention, school funding formulas, college access/affordability, early childhood education access, or chronic absenteeism.
- Ground the problem in state/district-level data (test scores, funding levels, demographic breakdowns).
- Review existing policy levers (state funding formulas, certification rules, financial aid programs).
- Design a policy proposal with an implementation and evaluation plan.
- Identify equity impacts across district wealth, race, and geography (urban/rural).

Possible Approaches:

- Funding formula — a revised state school-funding formula addressing an identified gap.
- Workforce — a teacher recruitment/retention policy (pay, loan forgiveness, certification pathways).
- Access — a higher-ed affordability or dual-enrollment expansion policy.
- Early intervention — center on early childhood or literacy-by-third-grade policy.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy brief with data, recommendation, and implementation plan
- One-page fact sheet for a school board or state legislature audience

- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- A simple evaluation plan (what metrics would show the policy is working)
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Interview a teacher, administrator, or student (with consent)
- Draft model state legislative or board-of-education rule language
- Simple data dashboard comparing districts/states
- Cost-per-outcome analysis

Platforms and Tools:

- Data: NCES, state department of education dashboards, EdBuild/school finance data, Census
- Legislative tracking: state legislature websites, Regulations.gov
- Drafting/collaboration: Google Docs, shared repo

Judging Criteria:

- Evidence quality & data use — **25%**
- Equity analysis (urban/rural, funding, demographic) — **20%**
- Feasibility (political + fiscal) — **20%**
- Clarity of implementation & evaluation plan — **20%**
- Presentation quality — **15%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Use only public, aggregate education data — no individual student records (FERPA-protected data is off-limits).
- Guardian consent required for interviewing minors; anonymize identities.
- Disclose AI tool use.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.